

Australia's Trade in Goods Account, March

#trade

#australia



By Ryan Wells

Economist, Westpac

15:15 May 07 2026

 Share

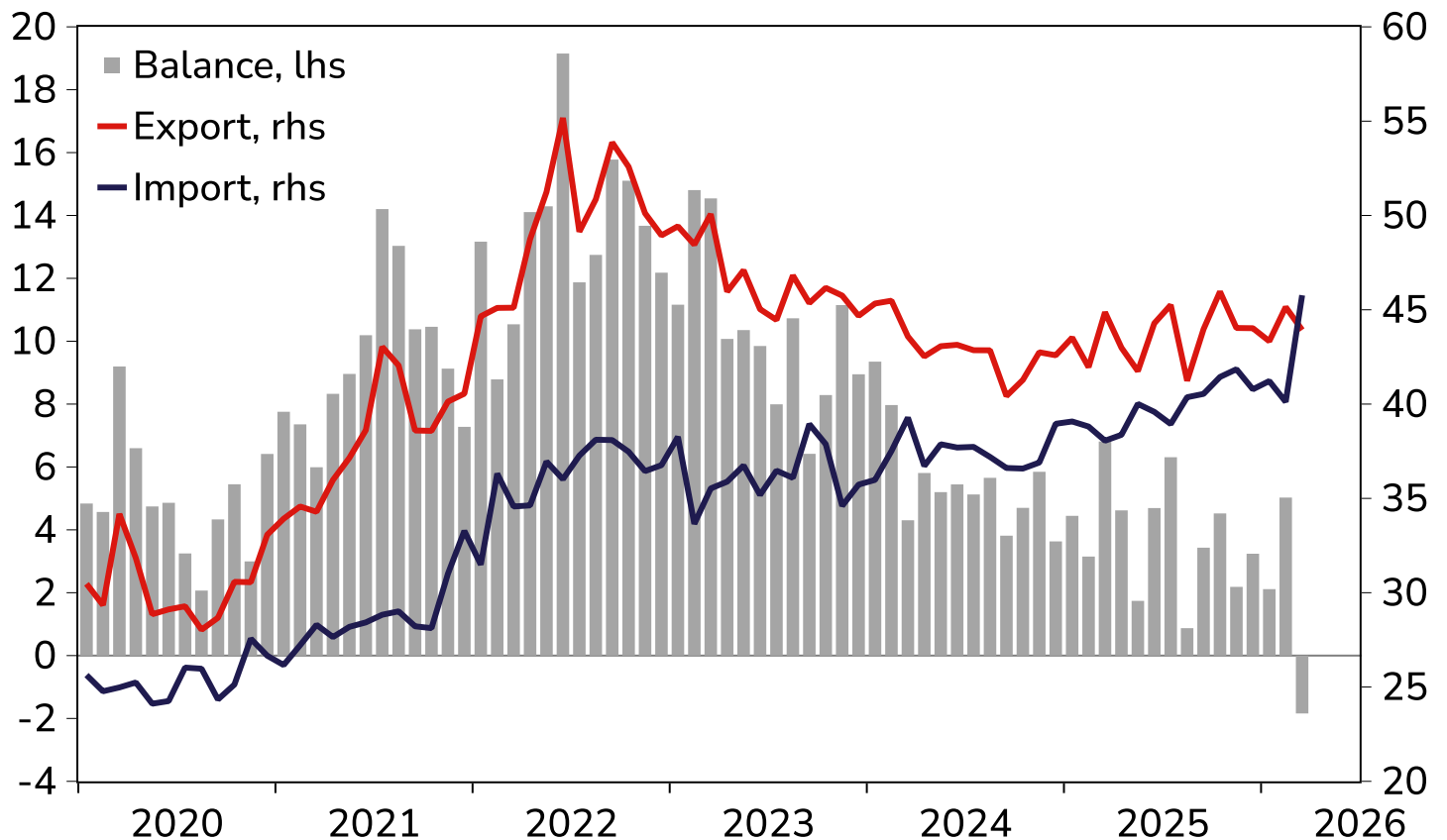
Australia's monthly goods trade balance fell into a deficit for the first time since 2017, driven by a combination of higher costs for fuel imports, continued volatility in gold trade, and most surprisingly, a truly remarkable surge in imports for data processing machines associated with AI. Trade balance: $-\$1.8\text{bn}$. Export values: $-2.7\%\text{mth}$. Import values: $+14.1\%\text{mth}$.



March's goods trade data surprised on many fronts. The headline balance collapsed from a surplus of \$5.0bn in February to a deficit of $-\$1.8\text{bn}$ March, marking the first monthly goods trade deficit since December 2017. Higher fuel costs stemming from the Middle East conflict was an important driver, but it was not the only factor at play. Most surprisingly, there was a truly remarkable surge in imports for data processing machines, often associated with the AI. Continued volatility in gold on both sides of the ledger were also a factor, alongside lower export earnings.

Goods Trade Balance

Value, \$bn



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Exports

Export earnings disappointed in March, falling -2.7% . An important driver of this was a broad-based pull-back in rural goods exports (-11.6%) from a solid showing in February. This latest move looks to be largely volume-driven based on other sources of price data. Rural goods exports have been more volatile month-to-month, but it is operating around a solid trend that has broadly supported export earnings of late.

However, the fact that non-rural goods did not provide any material offset to this was surprising, barely eking out a gain in the month (0.3%). Across our 'Big 3' commodity exports: coal dropped -1.8% , metal ores and minerals (i.e. iron ore) fell -1.4% , while the lift in other mineral fuels (i.e. LNG) was underwhelming ($+4.6\%$).

Additional data provided by the ABS on prices and volumes for these commodities revealed some

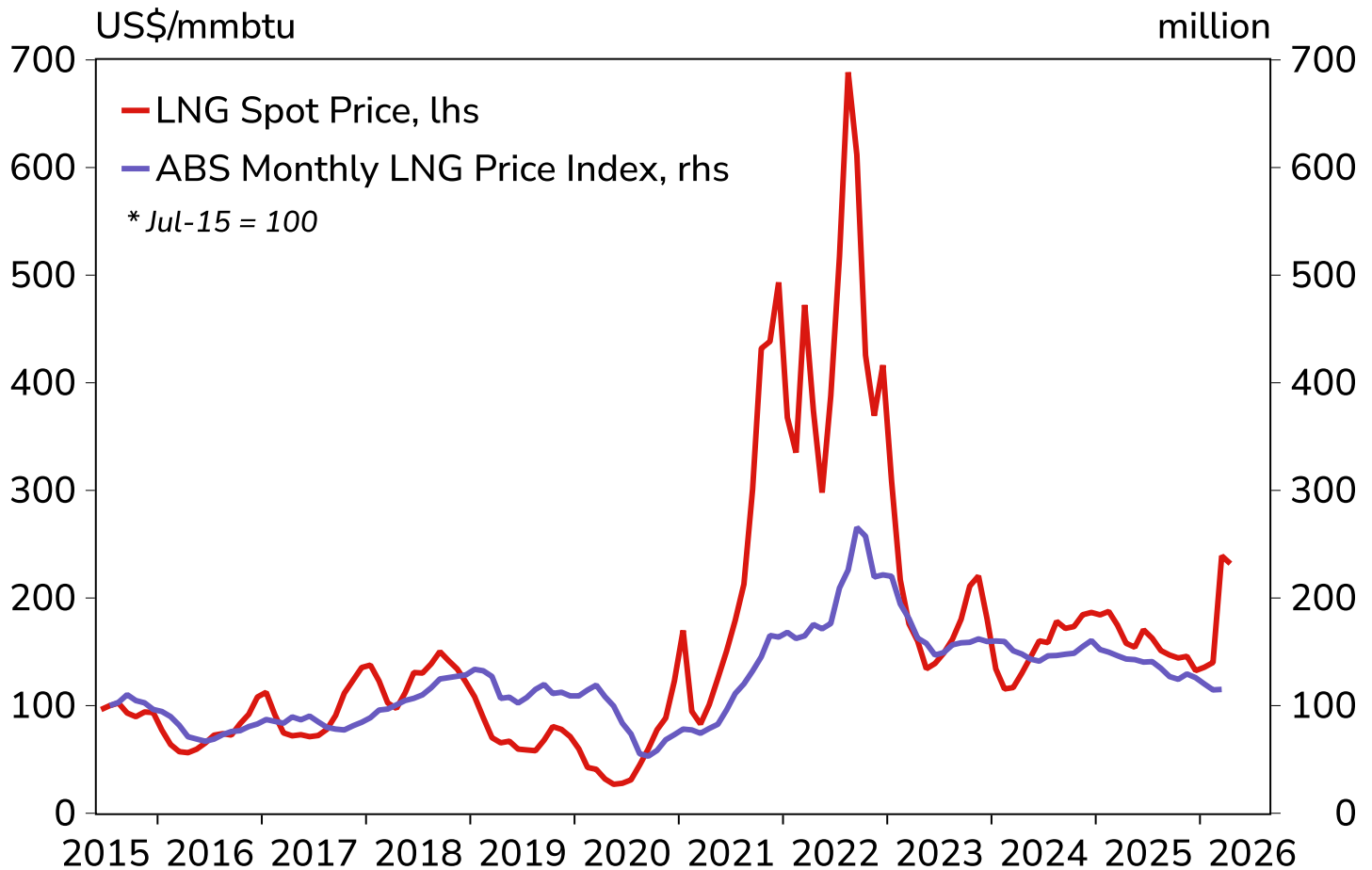
important nuances.

For LNG, export volumes lifted broadly in line with seasonal patterns in March, and interestingly, prices received was virtually flat in the month (+0.3%). Compared to this time last year, this export price index is –18.7% lower, given the broad decline in prices over 2025. This is a stark contrast to what we are observing in the LNG spot market, where prices have lifted notably since the onset of the Middle East shock.

That said, it is important to note that it typically takes a couple of months for changes in spot prices to feed through to the reported export prices in ABS trade data. The rate at which this can occur also depends on some extent to the scale of the move in prices. For example, while LNG spot prices lifted notably in March, it is nowhere near the extent of the 2022 Russia-Ukraine shock, which saw a relatively faster pass-through into export prices. Ultimately, while a significant lift to export earnings from LNG was not immediately apparent in the March data, it is reasonable to assume that we will see some increase over the coming months.

Meanwhile for iron ore, there was a seasonal lift in both export volumes and prices but it was fairly underwhelming compared to previous years. It was a similar story for coal export volumes too, although prices had a stronger showing in the month. Big swings in gold exports continue to add a layer of volatility – this time, contributing to the decline in export earnings with a –6.1% fall this month. This follow an extraordinary 42% surge over January and February, however.

LNG Prices



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Imports

The drop in export earnings was compounded by a surge in the import bill, climbing 14.1% in March, the largest monthly gain in over three years. Before discussing the story around fuel imports, though, it is important to mention that the bulk of this move came down to one line item: automatic data processing machines (ADP), which exploded a whopping \$2.9bn in March alone, a 300% increase. This likely captures many of the hardware components associated with AI, such as NVIDIA chips that can fetch US\$30-50k each. We had been consistently highlighting the strong uptrend in ADP imports over 2025 for this reason, but we are still puzzled at the sheer scale of the surge in March. This may well be a robust signal of the AI investment drive taking place on Australian shores, even if there is some noise in the mix.

Meanwhile, there was also 37.4% surge in petroleum product imports in March, reflecting higher global prices since the onset of the Middle East conflict. The ABS provided additional detail on the prices and volumes of refined petroleum imports in March:

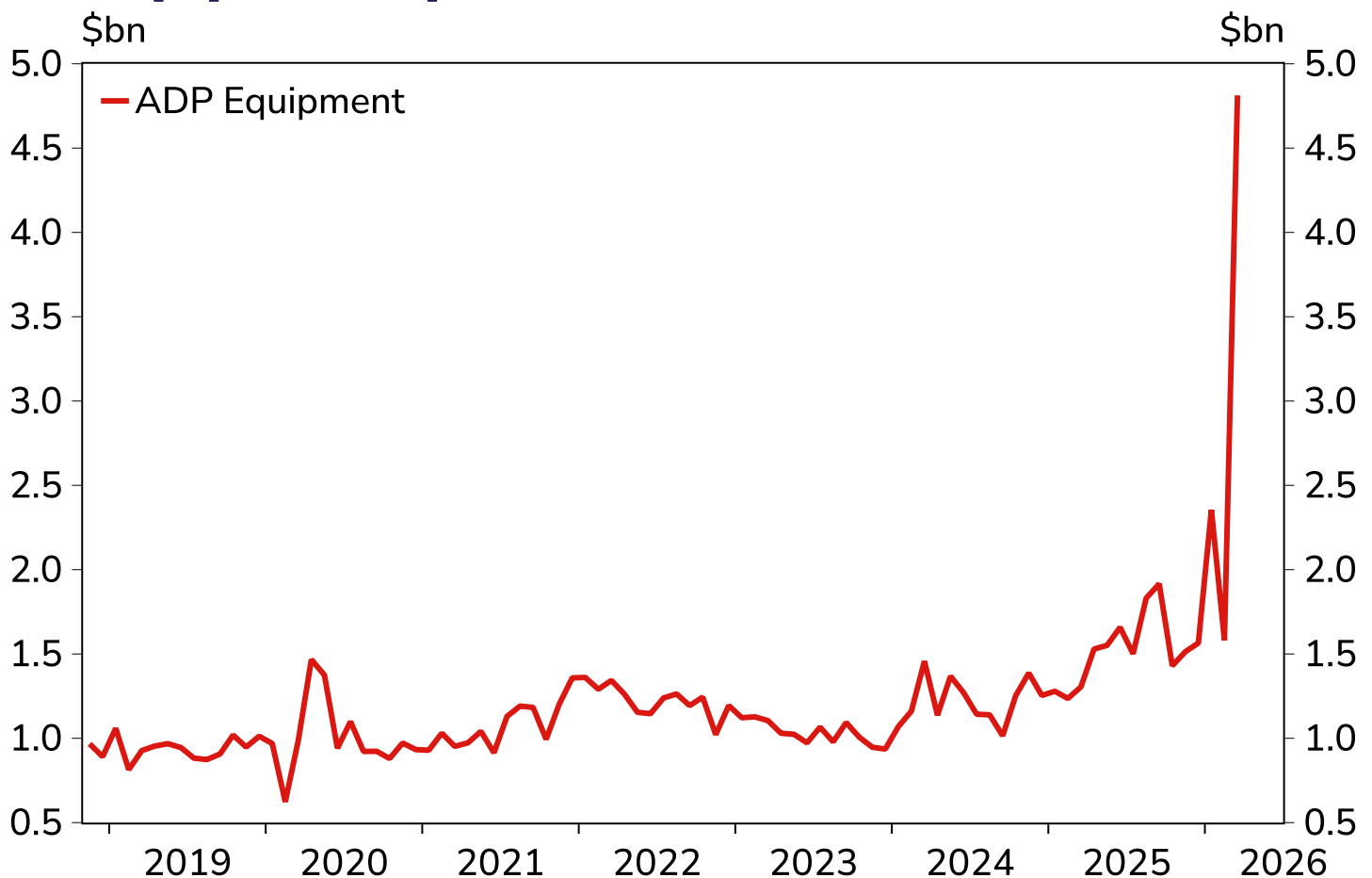
- Gasoline import prices rose 20.6%, and volumes imported rose 18.8%.
- Diesel import prices rose 42.2% and volumes imported fell -11.6%.

- Jet fuel import prices rose 42.7, and volumes imported fell –6.9%.

We are likely to continue seeing extreme volatility on this front over the coming months, as both prices fluctuate due to the conflict and volumes shift as authorities aimed to secure inventory. There is likely some lag in this data too.

Prices of and volumes for crude (unrefined) petroleum imports also bounced higher in the month but given its much smaller share in the energy import mix, it didn't have as much of an impact in aggregate, given we mostly import already refined fuel products. Extreme volatility in gold remains an important driver too, with import values for this commodity jumping 35% higher in March adding to the import bill. Consumption goods imports rose 1.2% in March, building on February's lift.

ADP Equipment Imports



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Overall, monthly data suggests that the nominal goods trade balance has narrowed by around \$4.6bn, from \$9.9bn in Q4 to \$5.3bn in Q1, driven predominately by a surge in imports, but also a weaker showing in exports. This provides a gauge on what to expect for the official reading on Australia's current account balance as far as the goods side is concerned – the main uncertainty, though, is the services balance, for which there are fewer current indicators to draw from. Additionally, large monthly swings has also made it difficult to pin-point just how much of the nominal goods trade data is simply due to price effects rather than real volumes.

Stay informed with Westpac IQ

Get the latest reports straight to your inbox.

Subscribe

Related articles



#trade

Australia's Trade in Goods Account, February

April 02 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By Mantas Vanagas

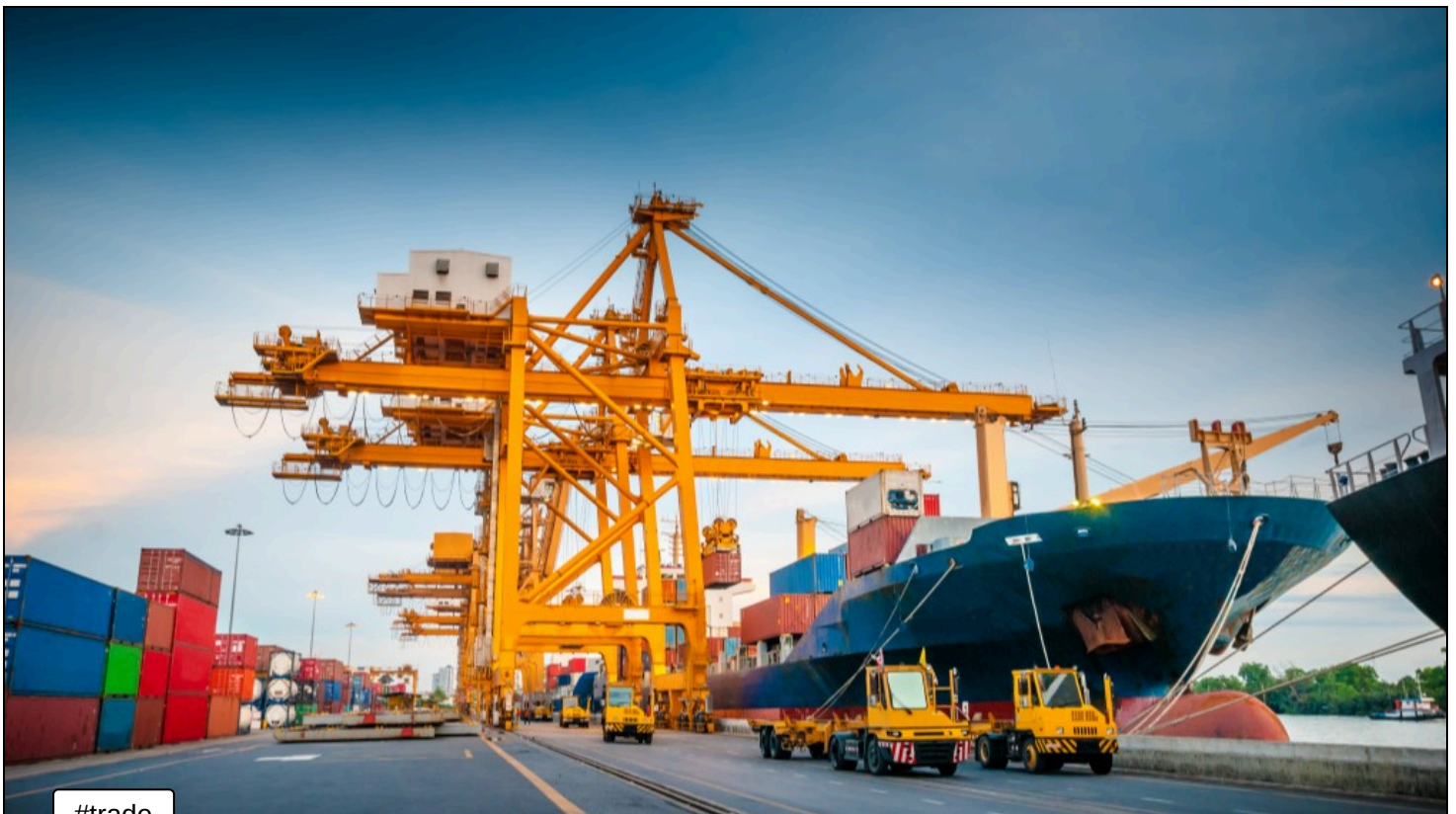


#trade

Australia's Trade in Goods Account, January

March 05 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By Mantas Vanagas



#trade

Talking about trade: more tariff uncertainty

February 27 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By [Elliot Clarke](#) & [Mantas Vanagas](#)

Browse topics

- [#aud](#)[#australia](#)[#interestrates](#)[#nzd](#)[#usd](#)[#newzealand](#)[#rates](#)[#credit](#)
- [#yieldcurve](#)[#acgb](#)[#inflation](#)[#rba](#)[#semigovernment](#)[#basis](#)[#commodities](#)
- [#ustreasury](#)[#fx](#)[#rbnz](#)[#jpy](#)[#abs](#)[Show more tags](#)

Disclaimer

©2026 Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 (including where acting under any of its Westpac, St George, Bank of Melbourne or BankSA brands, collectively, “Westpac”). References to the “Westpac Group” are to Westpac and its subsidiaries and includes the directors, employees and representatives of Westpac and its subsidiaries.

Things you should know

We respect your privacy: You can view the [New Zealand Privacy Policy](#) here, or the [Australian Group Privacy Statement](#) here. Each time someone visits our site, data is captured so that we can accurately evaluate the quality of our content and make improvements for you. We may at times use technology to capture data about you to help us to better understand you and your needs, including potentially for the purposes of assessing your individual reading habits and interests to allow us to provide suggestions regarding other reading material which may be suitable for you.

This information, unless specifically indicated otherwise, is under copyright of the Westpac Group. None of the material, nor its contents, nor any copy of it, may be altered in any way, transmitted to, copied or distributed to any other party without the prior written permission of the Westpac Group.

Disclaimer

This information has been prepared by Westpac and is intended for information purposes only. It is not intended to reflect any recommendation or financial advice and investment decisions should not be based on it. This information does not constitute an offer, a solicitation of an offer, or an inducement to subscribe for, purchase or sell any financial instrument or to enter into a legally binding contract. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the advice. Certain types of transactions, including those involving futures, options and high yield securities give rise to substantial risk and are not suitable for all investors. We recommend that you seek your own independent legal or financial advice before proceeding with any investment decision.

This information may contain material provided by third parties. While such material is published with the necessary permission none of Westpac or its related entities accepts any responsibility for the accuracy or completeness of any such material. Although we have made every effort to ensure this information is free from error, none of Westpac or its related entities warrants the accuracy, adequacy or completeness of this information, or otherwise endorses it in any way. Except where contrary to law, Westpac Group intend by this notice to exclude liability for this information. This information is subject to change without notice and none of Westpac or its related entities is under any obligation to update this information or correct any inaccuracy which may become apparent at a later date. This information may contain or incorporate by reference forward-looking statements. The words “believe”, “anticipate”, “expect”, “intend”, “plan”, “predict”, “continue”, “assume”, “positioned”, “may”, “will”, “should”, “shall”, “risk” and other similar expressions that are predictions of or indicate future events and future trends identify forward-looking statements. These forward-

looking statements include all matters that are not historical facts. Past performance is not a reliable indicator of future performance, nor are forecasts of future performance. Whilst every effort has been taken to ensure that the assumptions on which any forecasts are based are reasonable, the forecasts may be affected by incorrect assumptions or by known or unknown risks and uncertainties. The ultimate outcomes may differ substantially from any forecasts.

Conflicts of Interest: In the normal course of offering banking products and services to its clients, the Westpac Group may act in several capacities (including issuer, market maker, underwriter, distributor, swap counterparty and calculation agent) simultaneously with respect to a financial instrument, giving rise to potential conflicts of interest which may impact the performance of a financial instrument. The Westpac Group may at any time transact or hold a position (including hedging and trading positions) for its own account or the account of a client in any financial instrument which may impact the performance of that financial instrument.

Author(s) disclaimer and declaration: The author(s) confirms that (a) no part of his/her compensation was, is, or will be, directly or indirectly, related to any views or (if applicable) recommendations expressed in this material; (b) this material accurately reflects his/her personal views about the financial products, companies or issuers (if applicable) and is based on sources reasonably believed to be reliable and accurate; (c) to the best of the author's knowledge, they are not in receipt of inside information and this material does not contain inside information; and (d) no other part of the Westpac Group has made any attempt to influence this material.

Further important information regarding sustainability-related content: This material may contain statements relating to environmental, social and governance (ESG) topics. These are subject to known and unknown risks, and there are significant uncertainties, limitations, risks and assumptions in the metrics, modelling, data, scenarios, reporting and analysis on which the statements rely. In particular, these areas are rapidly evolving and maturing, and there are variations in approaches and common standards and practice, as well as uncertainty around future related policy and legislation. Some material may include information derived from publicly available sources that have not been independently verified. No representation or warranty is made as to the accuracy, completeness or reliability of the information. There is a risk that the analysis, estimates, judgements, assumptions, views, models, scenarios or projections used may turn out to be incorrect. These risks may cause actual outcomes to differ materially from those expressed or implied. The ESG-related statements in this material do not constitute advice, nor are they guarantees or predictions of future performance, and Westpac gives no representation, warranty or assurance (including as to the quality, accuracy or completeness of the statements). You should seek your own independent advice.

Additional country disclosures:

Australia: Westpac holds an Australian Financial Services Licence (No. 233714). You can access Westpac's Financial Services Guide [here](#) or request a copy from your Westpac point of contact. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the

appropriateness of the advice.

New Zealand: In New Zealand, Westpac Institutional Bank refers to the brand under which products and services are provided by either Westpac (NZ division) or Westpac New Zealand Limited (company number 1763882), the New Zealand incorporated subsidiary of Westpac ("WNZL"). Any product or service made available by WNZL does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WNZL). Neither Westpac nor its other subsidiaries guarantee or otherwise support the performance of WNZL in respect of any such product. WNZL is not an authorised deposit-taking institution for the purposes of Australian prudential standards. The current disclosure statements for the New Zealand branch of Westpac and WNZL can be obtained at the internet address www.westpac.co.nz.

Singapore: This material has been prepared and issued for distribution in Singapore to institutional investors, accredited investors and expert investors (as defined in the applicable Singapore laws and regulations) only. Recipients of this material in Singapore should contact Westpac Singapore Branch in respect of any matters arising from, or in connection with, this material. Westpac Singapore Branch holds a wholesale banking licence and is subject to supervision by the Monetary Authority of Singapore.

Fiji: Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac Fiji are available from www.westpac.com.fj © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia and registered as a branch in Fiji. The liability of its members is limited.

Papua New Guinea: Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac PNG are available from www.westpac.com.pg © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia. Westpac is represented in Papua New Guinea by Westpac Bank - PNG - Limited. The liability of its members is limited.

U.S.: Westpac operates in the United States of America as a federally licensed branch, regulated by the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency. Westpac is also registered with the US Commodity Futures Trading Commission ("CFTC") as a Swap Dealer, but is neither registered as, or affiliated with, a Futures Commission Merchant registered with the US CFTC. The services and products referenced above are not insured by the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation ("FDIC"). Westpac Capital Markets, LLC ('WCM'), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Westpac, is a broker-dealer registered under the U.S. Securities Exchange Act of 1934 ('the Exchange Act') and member of the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority ('FINRA'). In accordance with APRA's Prudential Standard 222 'Association with Related Entities', Westpac does not stand behind WCM other than as provided for in certain legal agreements between Westpac and WCM and obligations of WCM do not represent

liabilities of Westpac.

This communication is provided for distribution to U.S. institutional investors in reliance on the exemption from registration provided by Rule 15a-6 under the Exchange Act and is not subject to all of the independence and disclosure standards applicable to debt research reports prepared for retail investors in the United States. WCM is the U.S. distributor of this communication and accepts responsibility for the contents of this communication. Transactions by U.S. customers of any securities referenced herein should be effected through WCM. All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WCM. If you would like to speak to someone regarding any security mentioned herein, please contact WCM on +1 212 389 1269. Investing in any non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments mentioned in this communication may present certain risks. The securities of non-U.S. issuers may not be registered with, or be subject to the regulations of, the SEC in the United States. Information on such non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments may be limited. Non-U.S. companies may not be subject to audit and reporting standards and regulatory requirements comparable to those in effect in the United States. The value of any investment or income from any securities or related derivative instruments denominated in a currency other than U.S. dollars is subject to exchange rate fluctuations that may have a positive or adverse effect on the value of or income from such securities or related derivative instruments.

The author of this communication is employed by Westpac and is not registered or qualified as a research analyst, representative, or associated person of WCM or any other U.S. broker-dealer under the rules of FINRA, any other U.S. self-regulatory organisation, or the laws, rules or regulations of any State. Unless otherwise specifically stated, the views expressed herein are solely those of the author and may differ from the information, views or analysis expressed by Westpac and/or its affiliates.

UK: The London branch of Westpac is authorised in the United Kingdom by the Prudential Regulation Authority (PRA) and is subject to regulation by the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) and limited regulation by the PRA (Financial Services Register number: 124586). The London branch of Westpac is registered at Companies House as a branch established in the United Kingdom (Branch No. BR000106). Details about the extent of the regulation of Westpac's London branch by the PRA are available from us on request.

This communication is not being made to or distributed to, and must not be passed on to, the general public in the United Kingdom. Rather, this communication is being made only to and is directed at (a) those persons falling within the definition of Investment Professionals (set out in Article 19(5) of the Financial Services and Markets Act 2000 (Financial Promotion) Order 2005 (the "Order")); (b) those persons falling within the definition of high net worth companies, unincorporated associations etc. (set out in Article 49(2) of the Order; (c) other persons to whom it may lawfully be communicated in accordance with the Order or (d) any persons to whom it may otherwise lawfully be made (all such persons together being referred to as "relevant persons"). Any person who is not a relevant person should not act or rely on this communication or any of its contents. In the same way, the information contained in this communication is intended for "eligible counterparties" and

“professional clients” as defined by the rules of the Financial Conduct Authority and is not intended for “retail clients”. Westpac expressly prohibits you from passing on the information in this communication to any third party.

European Economic Area (“EEA”): This material may be distributed to you by either: (i) Westpac directly, or (ii) Westpac Europe GmbH (“WEG”) under a sub-licensing arrangement. WEG has not edited or otherwise modified the content of this material. WEG is authorised in Germany by the Federal Financial Supervision Authority (‘BaFin’) and subject to its regulation. WEG’s supervisory authorities are BaFin and the German Federal Bank (‘Deutsche Bundesbank’). WEG is registered with the commercial register (‘Handelsregister’) of the local court of Frankfurt am Main under registration number HRB 118483. In accordance with APRA’s Prudential Standard 222 ‘Association with Related Entities’, Westpac does not stand behind WEG other than as provided for in certain legal agreements (a risk transfer, sub-participation and collateral agreement) between Westpac and WEG and obligations of WEG do not represent liabilities of Westpac. Any product or service made available by WEG does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WEG). All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WEG.

This communication is not intended for distribution to, or use by any person or entity in any jurisdiction or country where such distribution or use would be contrary to local law or regulation.

This communication contains general commentary, research, and market colour. The communication does not constitute investment advice. The material may contain an ‘investment recommendation’ and/or ‘information recommending or suggesting an investment’, both as defined in Regulation (EU) No 596/2014 (including as applicable in the United Kingdom) (“MAR”). In accordance with the relevant provisions of MAR, reasonable care has been taken to ensure that the material has been objectively presented and that interests or conflicts of interest of the sender concerning the financial instruments to which that information relates have been disclosed.

Investment recommendations must be read alongside the specific disclosure which accompanies them and the general disclosure which can be found [here](#). Such disclosure fulfils certain additional information requirements of MAR and associated delegated legislation and by accepting this communication you acknowledge that you are aware of the existence of such additional disclosure and its contents.

To the extent this communication comprises an investment recommendation it is classified as non-independent research. It has not been prepared in accordance with legal requirements designed to promote the independence of investment research and therefore constitutes a marketing communication. Further, this communication is not subject to any prohibition on dealing ahead of the dissemination of investment research.